Praise of Confession

Deśanāstava · Toh 1159 · Derge Tengyur
བཤགས་པའི་བསྟོད་པ

The Praise of Confession, in Sanskrit Deśanāstava and in Tibetan Shakpé Töpa, is a hymn in verse by the master Candragomin, addressed to the Buddha as the unequaled king of physicians. In it the poet lays bare his own spiritual sickness: a mind churned by the afflictions, meditation that swings between laxity and excitement, good qualities that turn to faults in his hands, and remedies that seem to fail him, all described through vivid images of disease, poison and medicine. Against this he sets the Buddha's teaching, his presence and his dharmakāya as the cure that destroys the seeds of the afflictions, and he closes by dedicating the merit of his praise so that all beings may reach Sukhāvatī, the Land of Bliss. It is Toh 1159 in the Tengyur, in the section of praises, or stotras, and it was translated into Tibetan by the Indian preceptor Śraddhākaravarman and the chief editor-translator Rinchen Zangpo.

In the language of India: deśan stava
In the language of Tibet: Praise of Confession

Homage to the youthful Mañjuśrī.

King of physicians, unequaled, lord of beings,
Free of all faults, source from which good qualities spring:
Turning my mind to you, my refuge, I who am always sick
Shall describe the disorders of my own faults and confess them.

Like the current of a river very hard to cross,
With waves of wrong thought and analysis,
Churned up by the seizing sea monsters of the afflictions,
Even my own mind knows no peace.

When the waves of the ocean of desire surge high,
If I rely on the raft of impurity,
Then my mind is surely burned by the fire of aversion
Like dry grass, and destroyed.

To quell the torment of the fire of aversion,
Even if I cultivate the pool of loving-kindness,
Then, as I wish all people to be happy,
My mind is caught in the mire of attachment.

To wash away the stain of the mire of attachment,
Even if I cleanse it with the water of equanimity,
Then compassion too, protector of the world,
Which dispels the misery of all beings, decays.

Lord, if I cultivate compassion,
Great sorrow arises in me on every side.
If, to calm it, I rely on joy,
My restless mind turns to mere laughter.

If, to calm the joy, I arouse disenchantment,
Then my mind helplessly sinks into dejection.
If by effort I lift it up from that lowness,
It falls into the domain of the enemy, pride.

If, as its antidote, I meditate that all is empty,
Then I lose my zeal for the benefit of others.
If for their sake I rely on the conventional,
Then thoughts of wealth arise in my mind.

If I set my mind on wealth and the like,
I am made to drink the liquor of every fault,
And, drunk with the sleep of arrogance and bewilderment,
All that I aspired to is brought to ruin.

Even when I wish to give,
Mighty avarice firmly holds me back.
And if I dispel it and somehow go through with it,
Then for a long time afterward I regret it.

Even if, through faith, I come to trust again,
It lapses into seeking fruit in the world beyond.
If, knowing impermanence, I cease to hope,
Then, with no reason left, I sink into laziness.

Protector, when I see the world tormented by suffering
And look upon those who were once my kin,
Even if I wish to act for the benefit of others,
The perception of a self seizes me helplessly.

Pride follows in the wake of the view of self
And grasps at things, thinking, "These are mine."
Then pride, arrogance, desire, and the rest

Crush me utterly like enraged enemies.

When the net of afflictions, terrifying
As the army of Māra, spreads everywhere,
Then, as on a dreadful night,
The darkness of the dark side deepens.

Evil deeds, I declare, bring remorse hard to bear
And births that turn to suffering, terrible to endure.
What harm could be greater than that?
And yet I engage in them myself.

If I turn back from harming others,
Which becomes the cause of every kind of suffering,
Wicked people, become my enemies though I did no wrong,
With malice like a sword's edge throw it into turmoil.

Even when my mind wishes to be patient,
It is then tied up by the bonds of their misconduct;
Blocked and tightly bound, it is dried up
By the fierce fire of aversion, bereft of love.

Just as the wise avoid a tree
In which dreadful snakes with venomous gaze dwell,
So the virtuous shun my mind,
Which harbors the ways of anger.

Like a stone scorched by the rays of the sun,
Like ash turned to dust, utterly dried,
Like a road blanketed with heaps of sand,
My mind gains no benefit from the rain of Dharma.

The protector of the world who, heedless of his own unbearable suffering,
As though striving for my good,
Benefits me supremely with patience and generosity:
Even him I cannot bear.

Whether I hate him, or flee and slip away,
Or am utterly distracted, or turn him back,
He teaches the likes of me without interruption;
Yet I do not think of such a one as my guru.

Though he is hard to find even if one goes and entreats him,
He is the supreme great medicine at the time for patience.
If I cannot bear one whose very nature is patience,
What other cause for patience can I have?

Their minds disturbed, seized by the rākṣasa of the afflictions,
Fevered, making no effort even for their own good:
Lord, when I see a world so deserving of care,
It is hatred that arises in me, not compassion.

People experience the fruits of their own karma,
And I know that all are perishing helplessly;
Though I have judged others to be without fault,
Behold my distorted vision, from the cataracts of bewilderment!

Though I myself am an ocean of faults,
I cannot bear even a fraction of anyone's faults.
Though others have patience and excellent qualities,
That I cannot bear them is a great wonder indeed.

Like clouds rising in the summer sky,
The massed clouds of affliction in my mind
Come and go again and again:
Wretched am I, lazy, devoid of all shame.

When the cold wind of affliction blows,
Though I am eager to conquer it with blazing samādhi,
The haze of sleep and torpor thickens,
And my longing for bed and cushion grows and grows.

My mind is made helpless by the noose of desire,
Burned by the fire of aversion, crushed by pride;
Riddled all over with the arrows, spears, and weapons
Of every fault, it helplessly swoons.

Recovering mindfulness, bound and suddenly terrified,
Utterly crushed, I sink into dejection;
And deceived by guile and deceit,
I wander, wretched, in the domains of Māra.

However much I focus on calm abiding
And fix my mind on it again and again,
Just so often the noose of the afflictions

Drags it helplessly away with the rope of attachment to objects.

If I apply effort, excitement arises;
If I let it go, laxity sets in.
Since the proper balance of these is hard to find,
What am I to do with my troubled mind?

If I engage in wisdom, excitement arises;
If I rely on holding the mind, laxity sets in.
Since the union of these is hard to find,
What am I to do with my troubled mind?

If I strive with exertion, excitement arises;
If I relax it, laxity sets in.
Since the middle way between these is hard to achieve,
What am I to do with my troubled mind?

Though the forest fire of meditative concentration
Has burned the forest of faults again and again,
Because the firm root of the view of self is not exhausted,
They spring up again before me, as if moistened by rain.

One who sees the stream as nothing but afflictions, karma and their fruits,
And by that seeing brings it to a halt,
Though he abandons even the stream of mind,
Is very far from striving for the welfare of beings.

Protector, one who, free of even a trace of attachment,
Has become indifferent to all beings,
The cause of his mind spent like a lamp whose fuel is spent,
Reaches the nirvāṇa in which the remaining aggregates are exhausted.

But the mind of awakening, which dispels the misery of all beings,
Is an elixir of nectar.
When I meditate on nonconceptuality as the cause of awakening,
Then I run after nothing but conceptual thoughts.

Though I meditate that all beings are like a dream,
And that none of them grasps at anything at all,
I still move within the very domain of the enemy,
The conceptual thought of a conceiver and something conceived.

Lord, look upon this utterly unbearable harm,
And grant me the stainless view.
Whatever I conceive of as precious,
That very thing is the first to fall to ruin.

Or else the fault is mine, from what I did in former lives;
What could the Blessed One do about this?
Even the sun, which clears away the darkness of the whole world,
Does not clear away the darkness of the blind.

For a leper whose disease has long shown itself,
Whose mind here too is ever bewildered,
And whose feet and hands have fallen away,
What can a few decoctions of medicine do?

The tree of the mind, which has existed since beginningless time,
Soaked through with the bitter juice of the afflictions,
Cannot be made into something sweet to the taste;
What can drops of the water of good qualities do?

My mind, the very nature of every fault,
Has become, how marvelous, the gold-making elixir of awakening:
Whatever good quality it is applied to
Turns into the very substance of faults, and so it stays.

Whatever has been taught to be a great medicine,
That very thing has turned to poison for me.
If right reasoning itself is the supreme elixir,
Then, where trust is lacking, it is not there.

That which clears away the surging afflictions
And gives rise to no further fault:
When I think, "That is right reasoning,"
I ask, "What is it like?" and once again I fail to do it.

Intention, latent tendencies, element and imprints,
Matched to the antidotes for the causes of faults:
When one meditates on that instruction concerning intention,
This will be brought to peace before long.

Protector, you who are free of all faults
And see the ultimate meaning of all phenomena:
Because you have taught it in many different ways,

It removes the seeds of the afflictions without remainder.

To see your body, ablaze with the beautiful major marks,
Abiding before me,
And to hear the nectar that the ears drink,
Destroys the seeds of the afflictions without remainder.

Lord, you have what is more supreme even than that:
You possess the unsurpassed sun of the dharmakāya,
Which, even when contemplated, never becomes the domain of beings,
And which destroys the dimness of faults: how wondrous!

With whatever supreme mind it may be,
Abiding in whatever calm abiding it may be,
He brings all faults to peace in every way:
To that Blessed One I pay homage.

Thus, whatever virtue, white as the lovely moon,
I have gathered by composing this true praise
That confesses before the one of unsurpassed qualities,
By it may all beings go to Sukhāvatī, the Land of Bliss.

The text called the Praise of Confession, composed by the master Candragomin, is complete.

It was translated, edited and finalized by the Indian preceptor Śraddhākaravarman and the chief editor-translator, the monk Rinchen Zangpo.

Translator's Notes

• Three evident slips are read in their plain sense: tog as rtog, "thought," in the second verse; ston nyid as stong nyid, "empty," in the eighth verse; and rnag dka' as brnag dka', "hard to bear," in the fifteenth verse. In the first verse the physician imagery plays on nyes pa, which means both "fault" and a bodily disorder (doṣa). "The raft of impurity" is the meditation on the body's impurity, the traditional antidote to desire.
• The opening stanzas describe the disciples' path: seeing the personal stream as mere afflictions, karma and fruits, the practitioner ends it in the nirvāṇa without remainder, indifferent to beings, in contrast to the mind of awakening. Rtsol is read as stsol ("grant"). Rigs pa, rendered "right reasoning", may also mean "the proper method". In the colophon the Indian preceptor's name, written ba ngdha ka ra wa rma, is taken as a garbled spelling of Śraddhākaravarman, Rinchen Zangpo's frequent collaborator.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.